
Handout, Session 4: Lightning, paying and getting paid

Keep this page. It is your quick guide to fast, cheap Bitcoin payments.

What Lightning is

Lightning is a fast layer built on top of Bitcoin. Think of it as a quick lane for small, everyday payments. Payments arrive in seconds and usually cost only a tiny fee. The sats are the same sats; you still hold your own keys in a self-custodial Lightning wallet.

The café tab picture: instead of paying for each cup one by one, you open a tab, pay as you go, and settle the total at the end. Lightning works in a similar way, so small payments are instant and cheap.

On-chain vs Lightning

- **On-chain:** very secure, takes about ten minutes to confirm, better for larger amounts and savings.
- **Lightning:** instant, very low fees, best for small everyday payments.

Use the right tool for the job. Daily spending goes over Lightning. Larger savings move on-chain.

A Lightning invoice

An invoice is a request for a payment. The receiver creates it, often as a QR code, and it can include a set amount. Once it is paid, it is used up.

- **To get paid:** tap "Receive," choose Lightning, enter the amount if asked, and show the invoice or QR code.
- **To pay:** tap "Send," scan the invoice or QR code, check the amount, and confirm.

A Lightning address

A Lightning address looks like an email address, for example `name@example.com`. It is reusable, so people can pay you again and again without a new invoice each time.

A real example: the Sats On The Road fundraiser receives Lightning at

satsontheroadafrica@geyser.fund.

[CONFIRM: whether your wallet gives each learner their own Lightning address.]

Safety reminders (still true)

- Keep only everyday spending money in your phone wallet.
- Your seed phrase stays on paper, never photographed, never typed into a website.
- Always check the amount and recipient before you confirm. Payments cannot be reversed.

If a payment fails

Sometimes a Lightning payment does not go through, for example if there is no good route. If it fails, the sats stay with the sender. Just try again, or try a slightly different amount.

An honest note

This course gives no financial advice and makes no price predictions. Bitcoin's price in [\[local currency\]](#) can rise and fall.

Glossary of terms: [../ ../ ../translations/GLOSSARY.md](https://satsontheroad.org/translations/GLOSSARY.md)